

CALIFORNIA STATE UNIVERSITY, NORTHRIDGE

The Effects of Bias on Performance Appraisals in Human Resources

A graduate project submitted in partial fulfillment of the requirements

For the degree of Master of Public Administration in Public Sector Management and Leadership

By

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“The roots of education are bitter, but the fruit is sweet.” My father would continuously repeat this quote. I always took it for granted and never took the time to understand what it truly meant. In drawing near to achieving a graduate degree, the advancement I have achieved has been astonishing. While working full time, I started a business that now has 12 employees. This would not have been possible without the knowledge I obtained from the program.

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## Abstract

### The Effects of Bias on Performance Appraisals in Human Resources

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Master of Public Administration in Public Sector Management and Leadership

Human resource management researchers stress the importance of performance appraisal ratings in organizations. These performance evaluations influence the competency, performance, and efficiency of employees. When conducting these reviews, rating instruments and competency are essential. The rater must refrain from bias and utilize the means necessary to generate an accurate rating. Raters are capable of being influenced by several biases, including the leniency bias, the spillover bias, the horn bias, the subjective bias, the halo effect, and others. These biases dictate the accuracy of the performance appraisal results. The chosen case study is that of LA Metro's performance appraisal process. This process was selected due to its multimodal appraisal, consisting of employees, supervisors, higher-level management, and teams. The findings indicate two major biases: recency effect and spillover effect. This process is also at risk for additional biases. It is suggested that the raters consolidate the views of employees, management, and teams in a manner that produces consistent and reliable results according to a rating system.

## **Introduction**

The purpose of this project is to examine the role of performance appraisal in human resources. This paper will strategize solutions to key challenges in performance appraisal as it pertains to the public sector (Ahmad & Bujang, 2013). This includes accurate, unbiased performance evaluation among raters. However, these raters experience deficits in knowledge as well as biases pertaining to social status. Their own subjective views may obscure the accuracy of the rating system (Adhmad & Bujang, 2013). A specific segment of the population is affected by this challenge, including managers, employees, and raters.

Therefore, it is key to implement strategies and tactics to mitigate biases, subjectivity, barriers, and inaccuracies in performance appraisal. Human resource management must master the process of performance appraisal. This process enhances the longevity of the organization by measuring the performance and competency of employees, who influence customer needs.

This topic requires study and research because performance evaluation enhances organizational competitiveness. Moreover, the company mission and vision must coincide with the appraisal process. This exemplifies the role of objective appraisals.

Several organizations can supply case study data and unveil methodologies and research pertaining to performance. For example, websites and journal articles are a rich source of data for performance appraisal. Online databases have a multitude of case studies for research purposes. In addition to reducing expenditures on research, they provide a source of observational data within a feasible timeframe.

This research topic is vital because performance evaluations can provide more accurate interpretations of performance (Ahmad & Bujang, 2013). The decision-making process contributes to optimization in the context of human resources and the organization as a whole.



Top organizations have mastered the art of quality control and improvement. However, this requires a reliable model of assessment and evaluation. Performance evaluations are one of the defining factors of effective performance and high work quality. Therefore, it is crucial to examine the performance appraisal techniques of organizations that have mastered continual improvement in the employee and performance context.

### **Statement of Purpose**

The statement of purpose is as follows. Performance appraisal in human resource management is important because it contributes to company sustainability and survival. Furthermore, employees ultimately dictate consumer and client needs. Performance appraisal can be used to establish successful career paths for employees, which will aid the company's longevity. This research will examine a case study of the La Metro performance appraisal process. The application of literature to this topic will assist in the dissection of LA Metro's evaluation system for biases, and this research will propose potential solutions to the evaluation biases that are found.

## **Background**

The history of performance evaluation and appraisal can be traced to time motion studies conducted in the field of engineering in the early 1900s (Curzi et al., 2019). The researchers utilized quantitative reasoning to collect data. In these studies, objective observers recorded data regarding the time and steps required to complete a given task. Next, they devised a strategy designed to optimize efficiency. Ever since this study, researchers have adapted these techniques to measure workflow, performance, and efficiency, utilizing distinct reporting methods (Curzi et al., 2019). This has inspired efforts to standardize data reporting and findings. Time motion studies specifically refer to the duration of the tasks one is observing, the rigor with which one trains, the reliability of one's assessments, and the number of tasks one completes. Each of these foreshadows the future performance appraisal assessments, which also measure efficiency, time, duration, and quality. The time motion studies consist of specific techniques.

This study was inspired by the study of industrial processes in the 20<sup>th</sup> century. Across the globe, corporations developed concerns regarding work and performance inefficiencies that led to the expenditures of material resources (Curzi et al., 2019). Frederick Taylor researched inefficiencies and the factors contributing to those losses (Curzi et al., 2019). His research added to what is known as scientific management. His time studies used a stopwatch during employee observations to determine the time necessary to complete given tasks. Eventually, Frank and Lillian Gilbreth expanded on these theories, emphasizing motion in their studies (Curzi et al., 2019). These studies enhanced process efficiency by reducing the motions necessary to achieve a particular action. Both time studies and motion studies became embedded in the context of scientific management.

By 1914, this knowledge was translated and adapted to the fields of healthcare and life science (Curzi et al., 2019). Both researchers and managerial leaders in healthcare implemented these methods to regulate costs. Eventually, these approaches were adapted to the business context. There is a substantial interest in this topic to improve quality, efficiency, and workflow while supporting decision-making models in organizations. Approximately 100 years after this management style was developed, researchers aimed to standardize the time motion studies, which created challenges (Curzi et al., 2019).

Modern performance appraisals also derive from a long history of human resource management. Organizations are intent on maintaining their competitive edge in the economy. To capitalize on their employees' innovation, potential, and efficiency, they must appraise their performance and evaluate their strengths and weaknesses (Curzi et al., 2019). There are several approaches to human resource management. Previously, performance appraisals were believed to enhance the employee's innovative behaviors. Formal performance appraisal is more likely to evoke employee creativity and innovation. However, prior studies have questioned the competence and effectiveness of traditional performance evaluations and appraisals (Curzi et al., 2019). In an effort to enhance their effectiveness, new performance appraisal instruments have been introduced.

As well as considering cost, efficiency, and procedure, evaluations should include quality tests. While some employees may be able to follow steps and meet deadlines, the value of their work should also be taken into consideration. On the other hand, while some employees work well while being evaluated, others may falter and underperform. Expecting evaluations may also result in performance anxiety, resulting in poor performance and lower quality of work. According to Hinshelwood and Skogstad (2000):

Although it is the individuals who feel anxiety and operate defences, a defensiveness can also be locked into the social system . . . Firstly, any work situation can cause work-specific anxiety – the work may be a dangerous activity such as digging coal, or guilt-inducing if it is work in a factory for weapons. This is a specific anxiety that is generated by the work and concerns everybody. (p. 4)

Mental health plays a role in employee efficiency and level of productivity. Experiencing anxiety at work can not only affect an employee's everyday performance, but may also have a great influence on their performance during their evaluation.

## **Literature Review**

### **Performance Appraisal Principles**

This section will address the principles of performance appraisal. These principles are essential to forming guidelines and standards with which performance raters can conduct evaluations. In an effort to develop a competitive edge, companies must engage in performance management practices (Curzi et al., 2019). Performance management and appraisal are among the most essential human resource management practices, as they delineate personal responsibilities and behaviors designed to align with the company (Curzi et al., 2019). Curzi et al.'s (2019) research on signaling theory helps identify which traits of appraisal are more likely to promote innovation in the workplace. The performance appraisal characteristics that are discussed may shape an employee's perception of appraisal. The more formalized a performance appraisal is, the less of a role perception plays in it. Therefore, formalization may reduce the input of perceptions and bias (Curzi et al., 2019). However, these formalized elements of appraisal fail to incorporate changes in employees and the organization.

Important facets of organizational life include the personality traits of the person who is rating the employee's performance, the rater's principles and beliefs about performance, and organizational attitudes (Tziner & Levy, 2016). In addition, an employee's traits may obscure or enhance the performance appraisal. Tziner and Levy (2016) suggest that the process of self-monitoring on the part of employees may aid job performance. This can influence their performance appraisal rating both directly and indirectly.

### **Performance Appraisal Challenges: Previous Investigations**

Perceptions of human resource management systems and their respective strengths and quality affect the performance appraisal process. Therefore, it is critical to moderate these

perceptions (Waheed et al., 2018). However, employee sensitivity and poor-quality appraisals can lead to inconsistent or low-quality feedback (Waheed et al., 2018). Furthermore, negative attitudes toward performance appraisal may result in conflicting goals (Feinauer, 1990). Along with reducing the bias of perception, it is recommended that raters mitigate the role of psychological empowerment in human resource management.

The performance of individuals can potentially be altered when in an evaluative setting. Whether the individual is an employee or a student, anxiety and stress present themselves at the times when their performance may cost them their career or passion. Heightened anxiety can result in the performer potentially creating higher-quality work, surpassing expectations, or performing with much lower-quality results. In a study focusing on music students' performance during evaluations, Mitchell (2011) found that:

This anxiety is often more pronounced in evaluative setting as students are aware of the higher stakes attached to this performance. While anxiety can occur in any performance setting, it is often heightened in evaluative situations. Performance anxiety is the psychological, physiological, and behavioral reaction to stressful situations, such as public performance and tests. When a student is anticipating a potential blow to his or her self-worth and self-esteem, he or she is likely to experience high levels of anxiety leading up to and during a performance. (Sinden, 1999, p. 32)

### **Performance Rater Biases**

Rater-based assessments should be avoided due to their orientation toward bias (Aubin et al., 2018). Leniency bias occurs in performance appraisals and is sometimes attributed to rater characteristics (Cheng et al., 2017). Another bias in performance appraisals is offering approval in exchange for approval from others (Cheng et al., 2017). Moreover, the organizational culture

may be more inclined to approve than disapprove (Cheng et al., 2017). It is crucial to enhance the rater's capacity to judge competency and performance and their efficacy in doing so. It is also important to outline which personality traits and rating aspects do not correlate to employee ability in order to eliminate bias. Peer ratings and non-confidential appraisals may obscure the results. Anonymity provides added protection of objectivity and accuracy in appraisals.

### **Performance Rater Bias Reduction Techniques**

Performance rater bias techniques are imperative in human resources. These bias reduction techniques can ensure optimal outcomes. Some contextual variables are designed to decrease leniency bias during performance appraisals (Cheng et al., 2017). Moderating intrinsic rating demands may also contribute to accurate performance appraisals (Tavares et al., 2016). Decreasing cognitive load will improve rating accuracy. Performance management competence is also inversely correlated to appraisal bias. One reason that quality ratings decrease is because the intrinsic need or demand for ratings increases. Cognitive effort is correlated to the judgments made on these evaluations.

### **The Lack of Bias Detection Statistics and Research in Literature**

Modern research is lacking in bias detection techniques and statistics. The appropriateness of responses on performance evaluation requires research on the response process (Aubin et al., 2018). Statistics can be used to uncover bias in performance appraisals (Aubin et al., 2018). These statistics lack data regarding their capacity to uncover slants or biases in the education system (Aubin et al., 2018).

### **Increasing Accuracy and Objectivity in Performance Measures**

Increasing the precision and objectivity of performance measures is critical in human resources. One such method to enhance rater performance is to improve rater performance appraisal behavior (Tziner & Levy, 2017). Another approach is to invest in rater competence, skill level, and personality (Tziner & Levy, 2017). Detection analysis should be implemented for discrimination and other forms of bias (Souty et al., 2018). Another strategy to improve objectivity is to include appraisals in several organizational dimensions (Javidmehr & Ebrahimpour, 2015). Individual performance evaluations establish a link between the ratee and the organization. There is often a lack of assessment in several dimensions of the evaluation process. However, decreases in bias-related errors can enhance organizational satisfaction.

### **Improving the Appropriateness of Score Analysis and Interpretation**

Score analysis may be improved through decreasing rater bias. A simulation may be implemented to do this (Aubin et al., 2018). Another effort that could enhance accuracy is to cultivate an organizational culture that embraces both approval and disapproval, as approval-oriented appraisals lead to bias (Cheng et al., 2017). A lack of emotional sensitivity and empathy may also obscure a rater's analysis (Cheng et al., 2017). Some raters are inclined to give their employees lenient ratings in order to obtain promotions or because they feel the pressure to grant approval in order to acquire approval for their own job performance. They may also fear that giving negative feedback will compromise their interaction with the individual they are rating.



## **Method**

The methodology for this project is a qualitative case study. The search strategy for this topic entailed conducting research on the Google Scholar, Virtual LRC, and NCBI databases. The purpose of this search was to produce literature results for the given topic.

The next component of this research was to conduct searches for organizational case studies and their experiences with human performance appraisals and evaluation. The results produced articles on several topics for each given search engine. The chosen case study was one that investigated the LA Metro performance appraisal process. Data was collected on the LA Metro performance appraisal process by contacting human resources at LA Metro to request their results and analytic information. Human resources provided employee demographics and used statistical data directly from Metro 50 to produce these results. Using the aforementioned research, the given case study will be analyzed accordingly. Each year, La Metro performs three employee evaluations: the Start of Year Review, the Mid-Year Review, and the Year End Review. LA Metro performs these evaluations in collaboration with consultants and performance review teams.

The Start of the Review commences at the beginning of the fiscal year, the Mid-Year Review assesses employee performance up to the middle of the fiscal year, and the Year End Review assesses employee performance until that date. Each employee is also given a performance appraisal conference. This provides each employee with an overall performance rating. Their performance appraisal instruments include Performance Factors-Values, Performance Objectives-Core Business Goals, and Overall Performance Rating. After the Year End Review is performed, supervisors supply employees with their appraisals, the employee reviews the appraisal to express their disagreement, and the appraisal is signed. This case study

of the LA Metro performance appraisal process will draw on the literature of this field to assess for biases, strengths, challenges, and potential improvements.

This case will be analyzed along the following dimensions for gaps, flaws, and overall quality. The performance appraisal process will be examined for leniency bias, primacy effect, halo effect, central tendency, horn effect, spillover effect, recency effect, and subjective/personal bias.

## **Results**

The findings of this case study are as follows. This performance appraisal process was evaluated along several dimensions. These biases included the leniency effect, the spillover effect, the individualized/personal bias, the halo effect, the recency effect, the primacy effect, the horn effect, and the central tendency. In some cases, a dimension was difficult to perceive in the context of performance appraisal. Therefore, the appraisal dimension was judged according to safeguards to control for those biases. For example, if the data could not be assessed for the halo effect, it was crucial to examine the appraisal instrument for indicators controlling for this variable.

The first dimension, the leniency effect, describes evaluating the employee according to leniency. In this case, the performance evaluator may ascribe too high a rating to a given employee. This leniency can obscure the results and lead to imprecise ratings. As per the case study, the LA Metro Performance Evaluation was relatively low in the leniency effect. This was determined by their support of the organizational values. The purpose of their appraisal is to uphold those values rather than bias the rating to benefit the employee. Another indication that this performance appraisal lacked this bias was the organization's commitment to professional development. For LA Metro, these rating systems are used to identify training needs and to provide targeted training to the individual. The leniency bias would prevent this objective. Therefore, the leniency bias is not a factor in this appraisal process.

The second dimension for which the case study was analyzed was the halo effect. The halo effect is the positive assessment of employee performance in accordance with a positive trait. This may refer to the employee's appearance, personality, or associations. These biases can obscure the outcomes of employee evaluations. No indications of the halo effect are contained in

LA Metro's evaluation process. The requirement of an upper-level management signature reduces the likelihood that the halo effect would be a factor in performance evaluation for this organization.

The third dimension for which the case study was analyzed was the recency effect. The recency effect describes a recent behavior that dilutes or obscures a former behavior. The recency effect is the most likely of the biases to be a factor in these performance appraisals.

The fourth dimension for which the case study was analyzed was the primacy effect. This effect occurs when the rater assesses the employee according to their first impression rather than current traits. This bias was not a factor in LA Metro's rating scheme, as their reviews were conducted three times per year to assess the employee's performance during three intervals.

The fifth dimension for which the case study was analyzed was the horn effect. The horn effect is evaluating an employee according to a negative quality or qualities. At LA Metro, employees are invited to partake in the performance appraisal instrument in order to identify their strategic and performance objectives. Therefore, the employee involvement prevented raters from fixating on negative qualities.

The sixth dimension for which the case study was analyzed was the personal bias effect. The personal bias effect influences ratings according to whether the rater likes or dislikes the employee. At LA Metro, this bias was mitigated by the performance review team and the inclusion of upper management in the review process.

The seventh dimension for which this case study was analyzed was the spillover effect. The spillover effect occurs when an individual is assessed according to their past performance rather than their current performance. This bias was potentially present due to the three

consecutive performance reviews, which drew upon previous rating scores or could bias the rater.

The eighth dimension for which this case study was analyzed was the central tendency, which is the tendency to evaluate all individuals as average. This bias was not a factor in this performance appraisal process. The appraisal process was individualized to the performers/employees, as indicated by the performance rating scale. This scale included the following: Unacceptable (U), Needs Improvement (I), Effective Performance (E), Commendable Performance (C), and Outstanding Performance (O).

Looking at the morale questionnaire provided to Metro Team members in the LA Metro case study, we see how employees working there feel about their job. Employees also write evaluations; these are used to give executives an idea on how to evaluate their management teams. There is a substantial drop in employee pride when asked how proud they are to be working for this company. Taking into consideration that these employee responses include those of performance evaluators, possibly presents a bias that we see in their evaluations of other employees. Being unsatisfied with work may result in intentional bias towards other while performing these evaluations in a negative annotation. Another potential bias can present itself, when employees are asked about how well informed they are on how to do their job well, results show a drop in percentage. Employees state that they do not feel as if they have enough information to do their job well. Once again, if an employee does not know the specific job requirements of their job as evaluators or the job requirements of the employees that they are evaluating, how can they be expected to perform a correct and accurate evaluation. A misinformed evaluator's bias is unintentional, in terms of not knowing what they are looking for while critiquing the performance of others.

A substantially lower score is presented when asked about the following aspects of a team members job, “My immediate manager cares about my development. My immediate manager regularly gives me constructive feedback on my job performance. Everyone here is treated fairly regardless of race, gender, age, ethnic background, disability, sexual orientation or other differences.” These questions results were scores lower than Metro’s benchmark favorability rate and they can directly correlate with employee performance evaluation results. As a manager who is responsible for employees in a certain field of work, their job is to maintain and educate employees in the best way possible for them to produce the best quality work, results show that this may not be taking place in this work setting, which harshly can lower the potential successful of an employee. Employees require feedback in a work setting in order to know what they are doing wrong and how they can improve, when this is not done regularly, we can see a spike in performance in employees because they are not aware of what they are doing wrong or how they can be working more efficiently and more correctly. The most concerning of the three aspects listed above would be workplace equality. Any type of discrimination and segregation placed between employees presents a bias and differs from LA Metro receiving accurate and unbiased evaluations of its employees.

The workforce at LA Metro consists of seventy-point five percent male and twenty-nine-point five percent female employees. Immediately we see that large difference in the number of males and females in the workforce, this presents room for gender-based bias in employee evaluations. The workforce at LA Metro can be seen as ethnically diverse. With a majority of forty-one-point two percent of their workforce being Hispanic. The second largest ethnicity would be African Americans at thirty one percent. Eleven point nine percent consists of Whites,

eleven point six percent would be Asian, three percent of the force being two or more ethnicities, zero point seven percent Native Hawaiian, and lastly zero point five percent American Indian.

Looking at the generations of employees, there are five groupings. The Millennial generation (1982-1998), there are 265 non-contract employees, and 2,343 union workers. The Generation X (1966-1981) grouping consists of 545 non-contract employees and 3,648 union workers. Next comes the Jones generation (1954-1965), with 556 non-contract employees and 2,816 union workers. The Baby Boomer grouping (1943-1953) has 125 non-contracted employees, with 508 union workers. Lastly, the Silent generation (1925-1942) has six non-contracted employees and twenty-seven union workers.

## **Discussion**

The performance appraisal evaluation process at LA Metro displayed several strengths and weaknesses. The biases in this model include the recency effect and the spillover effect. This can be attributed to several facets of LA Metro's evaluation model. During the Mid-Year Review, the supervisors use progress updates, therefore drawing on previous performance. The prior appraisal reports must be applied to this evaluation to gauge employee progress and to compare them to their current performance rating. While this is beneficial in measuring their growth and performance, their new performance may be distorted by prior assumptions. In this case, it is possible for the horn effect to occur. Prior performance evaluation can distort one's perception of the employee, particularly if their first performance review was negative.

Other areas of concern for this performance appraisal process include the halo effect and the leniency effect.

## **Limitations**

There were several limitations associated with the case study. The qualitative case study design provided in-depth, complex, multidimensional data on specific topics. However, this model lacks generalizability to other contexts. The findings of this case study may not be duplicated consistently for different organizations. However, they can be used to inspire additional research in these particular areas.

## **Implications**

The first implication of this research is that employees should partake in the process to obtain employee feedback and integrate bottom-up data into the scheme of performance ratings. This can offset the performance rater bias from perceiving negative employee qualities, the halo effect, and the first impressions/primacy effect, among other biases. The employee is a present



influence in the performance evaluation process. Therefore, this individualizes the nature of the performance ratings, preventing such biases from occurring.

### **Future Research**

Future research should explore standardizing the evaluation process so that it includes subjective and objective opinions from review teams, supervisors, and employees while tempering bias through the inclusion of certain controls.

## **Conclusion**

In essence, the performance appraisal/evaluation process is rife with biases and challenges and requires objective and accurate measures. This research explored the place and importance of performance appraisal in a human resource context, devising strategies to address performance challenges in appraisal in public organizations. The topic focus was on eliminating bias from performance appraisal by raters (Adhmad & Bujang, 2013). Many factors contribute to inadequate performance evaluations, one of which is rater traits such as knowledge. Furthermore, specific biases, as outlined in this research, skew the results and understanding of employee performance. Specific strategies, instruments, and tools are designed to limit these inaccuracies in research.

As one of the defining factors of high-performing organizations, these performance appraisals must be assessed with accuracy. Furthermore, these performance appraisals can aid the overall decision-making process.

Upon review of the LA Metro performance appraisal case study, the following was determined. First, the process has several strengths, consistent with the objective model of performance appraisal. One strength of this appraisal process is that it decreases bias through employee, supervisor, and group-based evaluations. This enables one to produce the most unbiased performance review possible. Despite these strengths, this performance appraisal is riddled with flaws and limitations.

This appraisal process was evaluated on several dimensions, which revealed its relative strengths and weaknesses. One of the fundamental weaknesses of this appraisal process was the spillover effect, as the appraisal process drew on prior appraisal results. To enhance the process,

a single annual evaluation should be conducted with the aid of group, employee, and supervisor opinions/data in order to mitigate the overall bias.

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